form: is the gusto with which the Left and Congress teamed up and took on the might of the BJP and TMC a new template for 'secular' politics? CPI(M) leaders are not committing overmuch. It's a line on which they have infamously dithered in the past. But a t the Kannur party congress in April 2022, politburo member Prakash Karat had laid out a tentative outline. "Alliance with the Congress is part of our party line. We have an understanding with DMK, the Congress, too, has it with them. Similarly, in Bihar, we and the Congress are with the RJD. I don't see any front or platform or scope for any all-India pre-poll alliance. A combination might emerge later, but the alliance of all secular, like-minded parties will continue," he had said.



"OUR OBJECTIVE IS TO ALIGN ANTI-BJP FORCES. THEY'VE TO PROVE THEIR STAND... THERE'S MUCH TACIT UNDERSTANDING"

MOHAMMED SALIM
CPI(M) W. Bengal state secretary

Talking to INDIA TODAY, CPI(M) state secretary Mohammed Salim also negated the idea of any non-Congress front to take on the BJP. Even as those like Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao have reached out to various par-

WEATHER

WHEAT FEELS THE HEAT

By Rahul Noronha



India's food security may be staring at a crisis this year. At the centre of this is the rising mercury that has sent alarm bells ringing in the wheat-producing belts in states such as Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Bihar and Gujarat. The consistently higher-than-normal temperatures during this critical time in the wheat crop cycle are likely to adversely impact the government's output estimates. According to the Indian Meteorological Department (IMD), February 2023 was the warmest since 1901. The maximum temperature reached 29.54 degrees Celsius—1.7 degrees higher than normal.

The farm community apart, policymakers, too, are concerned given that lower production of wheat would have a cascading effect on Public Distribution System (PDS) planning, food inflation and, eventually, the general economic scenario. This week, Prime Minister Narendra Modi took cognisance of the harsh summer forecast and directed the Food Corporation of India to ensure optimal storage of grains.

In areas outside commands of irrigation projects, sowing of wheat was mostly done belatedly last year, in November and December, because of the delayed withdrawal of monsoon in parts of the country. A sedate spring would have helped, but excessive heat at the pre-flowering and flowering stages is now affecting pod formation and plants that have the seed formed in them. Heat has an effect of 'forced ripening' which leads to shrivelling of the grain and consequent weight loss. Rains, hail and thunderstorms in central India brought a temporary respite from the heat, but equally the risk of crop damage. And the heat is likely to return in the coming days.

Estimates vary, but a study by a group of scientists from universities in the US, Europe, Australia and China indicates a drop of 6 per cent in wheat production for every one degree Celsius rise in temperature. The excessive temperatures are thus playing a spoiler in India's plans for a bumper harvest. Wheat production was estimated at 112.8 million tonnes (MT) in the 2022-23 rabi crop cycle. In 2021-22, estimates stood at 111.32 MT, subsequently revised to 107.74 MT. The drop was a result of excessive heat in the days just after Holi across India. This year, the onset of summer seems much earlier than even that, almost a month ahead in fact.

The estimated increase in wheat production this year was mainly due to an addition of 0.13 million hectares (mha) in sown area, which took the total area under the crop to 34.32 mha across the country in 2022-23. "As farmers,